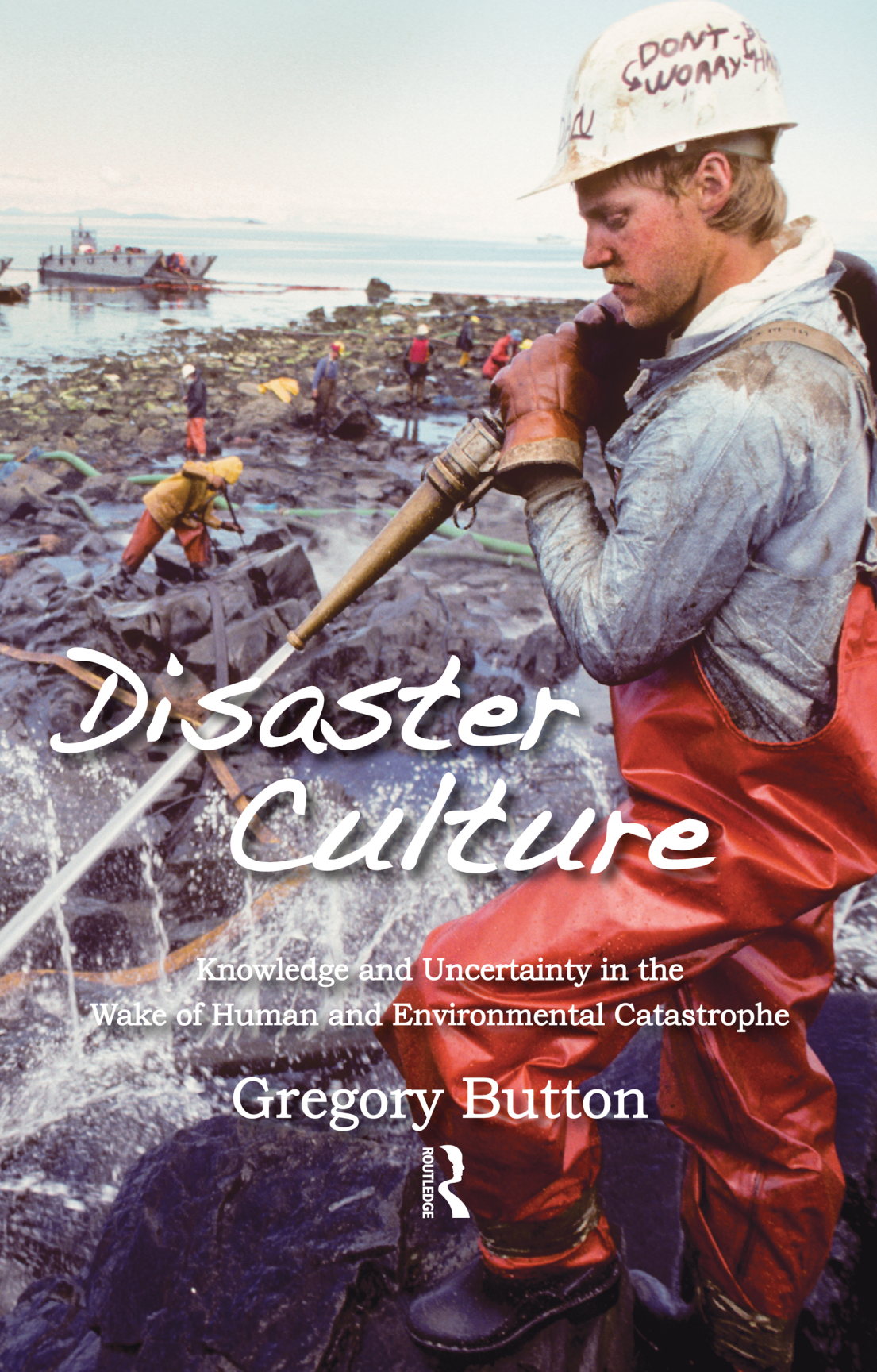




Disaster Culture

Knowledge and Uncertainty in the
Wake of Human and Environmental Catastrophe

Gregory Button

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Disaster Culture

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Wake of Human and Environmental
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Gregory Button

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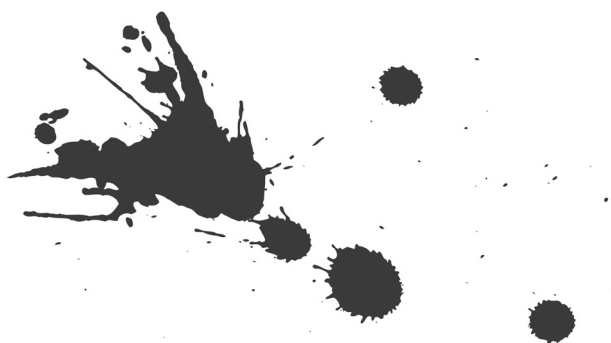
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This book is dedicated to all those who have endured
uncertainty in the wake of calamity.

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Abbreviations

NOAA	National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration
CDC	Centers for Disease Control and Prevention
CTEH	Center for Toxicology and Environmental Health
EDF	Environmental Defense Fund
EIP	Environmental Integrity Project
NIEHS	National Institute of Environmental Health Science
FEMA	Federal Emergency Management Agency
DHS	Department of Homeland Security
OSHA	Occupational Safety and Health Administration
ATSDR	Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry
GAO	General Accounting Office
HUD	Housing and Urban Development
NACOSH	National Advisory Committee on Occupational Safety and Health
NIOSH	National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health
USACE	The United States Army Corps of Engineers
USGC	United States Coast Guard
USDJ	United States Department of Justice
USDI	United States Department of Interior
USFW	United States Fish and Wildlife
MMS	Minerals Management Services
TVA	Tennessee Valley Authority
TDEC	Tennessee Department of Environmental Conservation
TDH	Tennessee Department of Public Health
ADFG	Alaska Department of Fish and Game
ADEC	Alaska Department of Environmental Conservation
ADNR	Alaska Department of Natural Resources
NRDC	National Resource Defense Council
LDEQ	Louisiana Department of Environmental Quality
LDPH	Louisiana Department of Public Health
NYCDH	New York City Department of Health

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Introduction

“The arrangements of society become most visible when challenged by crisis.”

Eric Wolf, 1990, *American Anthropologist* 92: 586–96.

Calamity is suffused with uncertainty. In the days, weeks, months, even years that follow a disaster, people feel uncertain about real and perceived risks. Information about the nature and extent of these risks is incomplete and typically conflicting. The parties involved in the disaster, as well as organizations such as the media, public agencies, and environmental groups, release a cacophony of communications that the affected population often sees as conflicting and confusing.

Disaster victims and the general public struggle to obtain credible sources of information. In an attempt to make sense of the event, they assign meaning, blame, and responsibility and develop coping strategies. Informational uncertainty can create individual and community-wide stress and result in a lack of effective coordination between responding organizations.

Uncertainty does not simply exist—it is produced, and the production of uncertainty can result in new political, economic, and social formations. This informational uncertainty generates conflicting public discourse about blame and the responsibility for remediation. It also raises questions about the severity of the event and the potential long-term harm that may ensue. Moreover, the informational vacuum that can exist in the confusion following disasters can produce harmful

rumors and misinformation. Sometimes opposing sides generate misinformation to manipulate the situation to their advantage.

In the calamity that follows a disaster, multiple uncertainties confront individuals and society. The cumulative effect can overwhelm the victims of disaster, and in the case of catastrophic events, it can overwhelm an entire society such as in the case of the recent (2010) earthquake in Haiti.

Even in a less severe disaster, citizens face stress from multiple sources of uncertainty: How can individuals continue to live and thrive after the loss of loved ones? Where will they live now that their home has been destroyed? How will they be able to survive without income? How have their lives been irretrievably altered by the loss of their social support networks? If they are forcibly displaced, how will they live as strangers in a strange land? How will they and their loved ones cope with psychological trauma; every time they have a cold or the flu, how will they know if they are presenting the onset of illness resulting from toxic exposure? How can they overcome the uncertainty over their environment? In short, how can their lives return to normal?

The Role of Science

Since science and technology are often involved in disasters, people often instinctively turn to scientists for answers, as do politicians, corporations, and public agencies. For example, following most unnatural disasters, conclusive scientific evidence about both the cause and nature of the catastrophe and the potential deleterious effects of exposure to toxic hazards is usually lacking. While the media seeks immediate answers to meet daily deadlines and the public demands instant answers, science, by virtue of its methodologically rigorous approach, cannot readily respond to these demands. Science can be a slow and painstaking process that cannot often produce the sound bites that the media demands or the reassurance or insights the public craves. Moreover, some uncertainties cannot be adequately addressed because sufficient scientific information does not exist (Nelkin, 1985: 18).

For instance, often no clearly calibrated safe exposure levels to toxic hazards exist. If such exposure levels do exist, their accuracy is often debatable. Usually, specific correlations with diseases, for example certain types of cancer, are unknown. As Devra Davis has astutely observed, “epidemiology is a blunt instrument” (2002). While there is, for example, sufficient epidemiological evidence to prove that radiation in some

cases causes various forms of cancer, there is no scientific way to establish whether radiation exposure has caused a specific case of leukemia. Inconsistent and contradictory scientific studies of the etiology of disease are often the result of imprecise understanding of disease. Under these circumstances, corporations can all too easily deny a disease-exposure relationship to toxic illness.

Usually, such an informational vacuum generates a climate of controversy both within the scientific community as well as with the residents who may have been exposed to toxic substances. Lay people are sometimes confused by the ambiguous or contradictory statements made by experts and puzzled about how to make sense of the ambiguities involved.

On the other hand, experts are often perplexed by the concerns expressed by disaster victims and their preoccupation with fear and uncertainty. Consequently, the two sides begin talking past one another. In such an uncertain atmosphere exacerbated by conflicting worldviews, citizens often become skeptical about the reliability of scientific evidence. Suddenly, some see the scientific discipline as lacking in certainty and incapable of resolving ambiguity. In the process, science's systematic invincibility is called into question, and its monopoly on truth is challenged. A dispute between lay and expert erupts. Whose voices are heard and whose voices are denied become essential to the contestation over the meaning attached to the disaster. Among those whose lives are disrupted by tragedy, the production of unhidden transcripts emerges during this period of conflict.

The Role of Corporations

Lay people are not the only ones who become disillusioned with science in the context of disaster. Fearing that litigation and increased regulatory control may threaten their profit-making activities, corporations demand a sounder science in order to influence public opinion, the media, and government agencies. The goal of transforming science and restraining regulation does not, ironically, result in the lessening of uncertainty but sometimes in the increased production of uncertainty. In this climate of scientific uncertainty, corporations cast doubt on their critics and seek to undermine challenges to the *official* narrative and attempt to avoid the scrutiny of government agencies. Corporations often resort to defining the event in a more limited scope in order to prevent government interference. Often they dismiss claims of critics by labeling them as junk science, "irrational," or "overly emotional."

Policymakers are then faced with the task of creating and implementing policy in a highly charged arena in which evidence-based policy is severely constrained and hotly contested. The climate of uncertainty is sometimes mutually constituted when government agencies seek to maintain the asymmetrical balance of power by protecting corporate and state interests over the public good. In some cases, government agencies seek to avoid the scrutiny of the public and other government agencies and either amplify uncertainty or withhold vital information.

Beneath the contestation over the status of science lurks the larger question: Just how much should we allow science to influence the political process? If science is to play a role, we need to ask “whose science” (Harding, 1991; Wing, 1998).

In this vortex of uncertainty and absence of knowledge, various interest groups turn to the expertise within the community. Amid all the conflicting claims and accounts, irreconcilable evidence and pervasive ambiguities, conflicting truths and differing canonical views of the event become polarized, which can either clarify the situation or accentuate the uncertainty. More often than not, the latter occurs.

The position the layperson and expert assume in these disputes is influenced not only by empirical facts but also by special interests, personal values, and the cultural and moral implications of a given technology. Very often opponents are embedded in their opposition to, or support of, various technologies and belief systems over and above scientific evidence.

The Production of Uncertainty

What becomes apparent in these discursive practices is that uncertainty is just as endemic in science as in other realms of life. This recognition has increasingly been employed as a tactic to create further uncertainty. Thus, in recent decades, uncertainty has become politically inflected. As we shall see, many corporations and public agencies involved in these uncertainties adopt a public relations strategy and policies that attempt to create either a sense of certainty in order to reassure and downplay the disaster, or, as a political strategy, contribute to a climate of amplified uncertainty.

On occasion, advocacy groups have also employed similar strategies, though not to date to the degree employed by corporations and the state. In such instances, science is often shaped, skewed, distorted, manipulated, or manufactured in order to retard liability or protect

polluters from government regulation or cast blame and responsibility on others. Such tactics not only manipulate science and create a smoke-screen of uncertainty but also serve to undermine our public regulatory systems. Consequently, citizens are made vulnerable to future hazards and our system of governance is undermined.

The Failure to Recognize the Important Role of Uncertainty

In recent decades, a robust and expansive literature on the nature and role of risk in modern day society has emerged (Knight, 1921; Beck, 1992; 1999; Giddens, 1998). This preoccupation has largely relegated the dynamic category of “uncertainty” to a black box. Too often uncertainty is trivialized. Risk discourse can be viewed, at least in part, as an attempt to overcome or lessen uncertainty and thereby protect citizens from future hazards of all kinds.

Although uncertainty is an essential part of the equation in mitigating risk, it has been neglected because admittedly it does not, at least from a rationalist perspective, lend itself easily to analysis. By definition, uncertainty is elusive and does not lend itself to the same scientific calculus that examines the nature of risk. Moreover, one cannot easily contemplate relative uncertainty in the way that relative risk can be analyzed. The notion evades the scrutiny of stochastic models and the technical calculations employed by most risk analysts.

Thus, uncertainty is too often relegated to the realm of the irrational. At times it is dismissed by analysts, policy makers, and politicians as some kind of free-floating anxiety whose pursuit is fruitless and threatens to undermine rational discourse. Ironically, some are reluctant to admit that this discourse is shaped by political, economic, bureaucratic, ideological, and cultural concerns.

The Need to Examine Uncertainty in a New Light

Uncertainty, because of its elusiveness, seems irrational. Its appearance as an internal rather than external threat seems most susceptible to psycho-cognitive analysis. Nonetheless, to limit our exploration to this realm alone and ignore the sociocultural, political, and economic forces that also foster uncertainty would be a mistake. Despite uncertainty’s expansive and elusive nature, common denominators about the nature of uncertainty can be readily observed as well as how this seemingly elusive category is being increasingly manufactured.

Uncertainty is susceptible to exploration and categorization if viewed as lived-experience and, more important, as being socially and culturally constructed. The nature of uncertainty can be explored by employing an ethnographic rather than a rationalistic approach. This approach can unveil the social, cultural, and political meanings inherent in the nature of uncertainty, which are too often ignored. By contextualizing uncertainty in the domains of culture, meaning, and power, we create a coherent idea of its role in society. Thereby, we call into question what is normative and what imaginative alternatives might be constructed.

This book, based on three decades of disaster research, is primarily concerned with the production of uncertainty as an ideological tactic. My goal is to examine how the conscious tendency to manufacture, revise, or withhold knowledge politicizes the discourse in the wake of disasters. In previous publications (1995; 1999; 2002), I have focused on how the media packages information and participates in the construction of reality, thereby informing us of some of the ideological elements that seek to maintain the status quo in the wake of crisis. Such packaging also reminds us of the often-overlooked fact that disasters are not merely phenomena in the material world. They are grounded in the politically powerful world of social relations. The analytical approach I employ underscores that disasters are not only socially and physically disruptive, they are also political events. Thus, disaster analysis must examine power relations among the various agencies and institutions involved in the event and the people affected by disaster (Button, 2001).

Whether labeled “natural” or “unnatural,” disasters highlight the asymmetrical distribution of power and foreground the struggle of the state, corporations, and human agency for the redistribution of power. The control of information in public discourse, as well as the attempt to control the social production of meaning, is an attempt to define reality. It is, therefore, a distinctly ideological process that we cannot afford to ignore. I view uncertainty as a prism for studying the social formations of disaster and seek to address the question of how politically generated uncertainty reconfigures both the landscape of disaster and our social arrangements. In the process, it inflicts greater harm in the wake of disasters and makes effective response difficult.

A Different Way in Which to Examine Disasters

This book provides a comparative analysis of the ways in which the politics of uncertainty is inflected in a time of calamity. By examining selected case studies based on my three decades of fieldwork research on disasters ranging from Love Canal, Three Mile Island, toxic groundwater contamination in Woburn, Massachusetts, the destruction of the 9/11 Twin Towers to the *Exxon-Valdez* oil spill, Hurricane Katrina, and the TVA ash spill, I attempt to unpack the significance of the nature of uncertainty in a time of calamity and propose a new analytical grid to understand the dynamic nature of disasters.

My approach is to employ ethnographic case studies to inform my analysis. However, I use the term “case” somewhat cautiously since disasters are not isolated events bound by space, time, or even concept, but rather are set in motion by a set of preconditioned series events and are followed by a series of cascading events that continue to unfold over time (Oliver-Smith, 2009). We usually perceive disasters as isolated and abnormal events. Disasters, like all social processes, are moving targets, which we can temporally isolate but not fully capture, in our textual analyses and more often than not our attempts to isolate them result in oversimplification. I employ a long-term comparative analysis in which we can distinguish disasters as routine and normal, connected to one another along various social fault lines and a direct product of our culture, not something to be imagined as simply an exceptional event. If we conceive of them in this sense they do not represent a traditional bounded unit of analysis that typifies normal case studies. Like Fortun’s (2001) observation on Bhopal, these and all manifestations of categories we label “disasters” are not bounded, but belong to a larger set of spiraling events. Thus, what I refer to as “case studies” in this instance are more like freeze frames of crisis, momentarily captured in time and space simply for the ease of analysis. Like all disasters, they continue to unfold across all traditional boundaries and across time. In some sense, disasters are similar to the way in which Clifford and Marcus (1986: 18) describe cultures, “contested, temporal, and emergent.” Hopefully, these case studies and the comparative analysis that follows can become useful stepping-stones for rendering a more holistic account of the political dynamics of uncertainty in times of calamity.

Each of the six ethnographic accounts of disasters has something specific to say about the nature of uncertainty in times of calamity. At

Introduction

the same time, the six examples share common recurrent themes that tell us on a general scale about how we as a culture respond to disasters. The six chapters are followed by four chapters that provide an analytical approach by which to investigate the production of uncertainty and the sequestration of knowledge.

Following this introduction, I provide accounts of the *Exxon-Valdez* oil spill, which introduces some of the primary themes of the book, as well as informs the reader about the nature of that specific event. Each of the case studies that follow demonstrates the lessons learned, or not learned, from the different disasters while demonstrating recurrent patterns that show how uncertainty and limited access to knowledge play formative roles in our culture's response to disaster.

The seventh case study on the BP Deepwater spill was added as this book was being prepared for publication. It not only serves to underscore dramatically the recurrent themes of the book, but also presents the persistent harm inflicted by the manufacture of uncertainty up to the present day. I hope that this new tragic chapter in our history, which is positioned in a long line of similar tragedies, will force us to reexamine underlying causes of this spiraling series of events.

In the analytical chapters that follow the case histories, I examine some of the perduring themes of the book, such as mediated accounts of disasters, the contestation over knowledge, the production of uncertainty, and the sequestration of knowledge in journalistic, scientific, legal, governmental, and corporate domains. These chapters also introduce broader accounts of disasters with the intent of demonstrating how endemic the production of uncertainty is in our society.

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